

# Session 6 Worksheet: Behavioural Experiments - Testing the Beliefs

CBT for OCD | Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Clinician: \_\_\_\_\_

Talking about a belief helps, but TESTING it in real life is what changes it. This session uses small, safe behavioural experiments to check two beliefs common in OCD: (1) that thinking something makes it happen or makes me bad (thought-action fusion), and (2) that suppressing a thought works.

Experiments are designed with your clinician to be safe. If any experiment raises safety concerns, it is adapted or paused. The aim is to gather information, not to prove you 'wrong' or push distress unsafely.

## A. The 'thinking makes it happen' experiment (thought-action fusion)

Pick a NEUTRAL, harmless prediction to test first (e.g. deliberately think of a specific harmless event and see if thinking it makes it occur). Record what you predict vs what actually happens.

**Belief I am testing:** "Thinking a thought makes it happen / makes me responsible."

**Belief strength before (0-100%):** \_\_\_\_\_

**The experiment (what I will deliberately think):** \_\_\_\_\_

**What I predict will happen:** \_\_\_\_\_

What actually happened: \_\_\_\_\_

**Belief strength after (0-100%):** \_\_\_\_\_

**What I learned:** \_\_\_\_\_

## B. The suppression experiment (does blocking work?)

Two parts. Part 1: for one minute, try NOT to think of a chosen image (e.g. a white bear) - count how often it pops up. Part 2: for one minute, allow any thought freely. Compare.

|                               | How many times the thought came | How distressing (0-100) |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------|
| Part 1: TRYING to suppress it |                                 |                         |
| Part 2: ALLOWING it freely    |                                 |                         |

**What did suppression do to the thought?** \_\_\_\_\_

Take-home: fighting or blocking a thought usually makes it stronger and stickier. Allowing it to come and go (defusion) takes away its power.

## C. Cognitive defusion - letting thoughts pass

Practise relating to the thought differently, instead of arguing with it or obeying it:

- Label it: "I'm having the thought that ..." rather than "... is true."
- Picture the thought as a leaf on a stream / a car passing / a pop-up ad, and let it go by.
- Thank the mind ("thanks, brain") and return attention to what you were doing.

- Say the word/thought slowly many times until it loses its charge.

#### **D. Planning my own behavioural experiment**

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| Belief to test | Experiment (what I'll do) | Prediction | Result | New belief % |
|----------------|---------------------------|------------|--------|--------------|
|                |                           |            |        |              |
|                |                           |            |        |              |

#### **E. Reflection & homework**

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What did the experiments tell me about my OCD beliefs?

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Homework: run the agreed experiment(s) between sessions, practise defusion when an intrusion arrives, and resist the urge to suppress, check, or seek reassurance. Record what happens.